

Visual art of the United States or **American art** is [visual art](#) made in the [United States](#) or by U.S. artists. Before colonization there were many flourishing traditions of [Native American art](#), and where the Spanish colonized [Spanish Colonial architecture](#) and the accompanying styles in other media were quickly in place. Early colonial art on the [East Coast](#) initially relied on artists from Europe, with [John White](#) (1540-c. 1593) the earliest example. In the late 18th and early 19th centuries, artists primarily painted portraits, and some landscapes in a style based mainly on [English painting](#). Furniture-makers imitating English styles and similar craftsmen were also established in the major cities, but in the English colonies, locally made pottery remained [resolutely utilitarian](#) until the 19th century, with fancy products imported.

But in the later 18th century two U.S. artists, [Benjamin West](#) and [John Singleton Copley](#), became the most successful painters in London of [history painting](#), then regarded as the highest form of art, giving the first sign of an emerging force in [Western art](#). American artists who remained at home became increasingly skilled, although there was little awareness of them in Europe. In the early 19th century the infrastructure to train artists began to be established, and from 1820 the [Hudson River School](#) began to produce [Romantic landscape painting](#) that was original and matched the huge scale of U.S. landscapes. The [American Revolution](#) produced a demand for patriotic art, especially history painting, while other artists recorded the frontier country. A parallel development taking shape in rural U.S. was the [American craft](#) movement, which began as a reaction to the [industrial revolution](#).

After 1850 [Academic art](#) in the European style flourished, and as richer Americans became very wealthy, the flow of European art, new and old, to the US began; this has continued ever since. Museums began to be opened to display much of this. Developments in modern art in Europe came to the U.S. from exhibitions in New York City such as the [Armory Show](#) in 1913. After World War II, New York replaced Paris as the center of the art world. Since then many U.S. movements have shaped [Modern](#) and [Postmodern art](#). Art in the United States today covers a huge range of styles.